MODULE 01 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

The Professional Architect

What the exam tests, the Claude platform on one page, and the clients we will design for.

SCOPE All seven domains ITEMS 63 MODULE 1 of 38

admin@sthithapragna.com

Knowing the API is assumed. The exam tests whether **the whole system deserves to ship**.

Who the exam is written for

- **Three or more years** in systems architecture or platform engineering.
- **Six months or more** running Claude, or a comparable LLM system, in production.
- **Discovery to deployment:** you have taken a system all the way through.
- **Not aimed at** entry-level developers, casual users, or prompt writing alone.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Recommended experience, not prerequisites. The exam result alone decides.

The paper

Items	63, multiple choice and multiple response
Time	120 minutes: about 1 min 54 s per item
Pass mark	Scaled 720, on a scale of 100 to 1,000
Results	Pass or fail, scaled score, % correct by domain
Fee and delivery	USD 175, Pearson VUE, online or test centre
Validity	12 months, with a free renewal assessment if on time

ON THE EXAM

Every item states how many answers to select. Read that number before the options.

Seven domains, and the question each one asks

DOMAIN	WEIGHT	THE QUESTION IT ASKS
D1 Solution design	17%	Which architecture, and why?
D2 Models and prompting	13%	Which model, which prompt?
D3 Integration	19%	How does it connect, safely?
D4 Evaluation	16%	How do you know it works?
D5 Governance	14%	What could go wrong?
D6 Lifecycle	14%	Who needs what, and when?
D7 Developer enablement	7%	How do teams build faster?

ON THE EXAM

Integration is the largest domain. Developer enablement is the smallest by far.

Where the marks really are

- **Design plus integration: 36%** of the exam.
- **The four technical domains, D1 to D4: 65%.**
- **Claude Code configuration (D7): 7%**, about four items.
- **A 125-item practice bank we analysed** gave D7 19% and D1 just 7%.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Study to the guide's weights, not to whatever the practice questions happen to ask.

One system's life, seven domains

01
Discover
D6. Goals, users, constraints.

02
Design
D1, D2. Pattern, model, prompts.

03
Integrate
D3. Tools, data, identity.

04
Evaluate
D4. Metrics, tests, tuning.

05
Govern
D5. Guardrails, review, compliance.

06
Hand off and run
D6, D7. Docs, teams, iteration.

ON THE EXAM

The domains are not separate subjects. They are stages in the life of one system.

The Claude platform on one page

Claude Code
Agentic coding
Team config, CI

Tools and MCP
Your tools, server tools
MCP servers

Platforms
Claude API, AWS
Google Cloud, Foundry

Retrieval
Your index, embeddings
Citations

Claude models
Messages API
Caching and Batch
Structured outputs
Haiku, Sonnet, Opus, Fable

Skills
Packaged procedures
Loaded when relevant

Governance
ZDR, HIPAA-ready orgs
Admin and audit

Agent runtimes
Agent SDK, self-run
Managed Agents, hosted

Evaluation
Your eval sets
Monitoring

THE TAKEAWAY

Most questions are about joining these pieces, not about any one of them.

Four tiers, one trade-off

TIER	REACH FOR IT WHEN
Haiku	High volume, tight latency, simple judgement
Sonnet	You want speed and intelligence in balance
Opus	Complex reasoning, long agentic work
Fable	The hardest problems; slower and dearest

CURRENCY CHECK

Today: Haiku 5.5, Sonnet 5.5, Opus 5.5 and Fable 5.1. Exam questions reason in tiers, not versions.

Where Claude runs

PLATFORM	WHY AN ARCHITECT PICKS IT
Claude API	Every feature first; ZDR and HIPAA-ready orgs
Claude Platform on AWS	Anthropic-run, billed through AWS
Amazon Bedrock	AWS as processor; GovCloud, EU regions
Google Cloud	Agent Platform, formerly Vertex AI
Microsoft Foundry	Hosted on Azure or on Anthropic

ON THE EXAM

The platform changes the features you get, who processes the data, and your compliance story.

First strike out every option that breaks a **hard constraint**. Only then compare what is left.

Eliminate, then optimise

01

Find the constraints

Regulation, data boundary, SLA, budget cap.

02

Strike the breakers

Breaks one? Out, however good.

03

Read the priority

Cost, latency, quality or effort?

04

Prefer the simplest

Least machinery that meets the need.

05

Check the qualifier

First, most directly, BEFORE, choose two.

ON THE EXAM

An option can be brilliant and still wrong. One broken constraint ends it.

What changed after the July 2026 guide

- **Models:** the 5.5 family and Fable 5.1, September to October 2026.
- **Tool choice:** Opus 5.5 rejects forced tool choice. Use strict tools with auto.
- **MCP:** a new specification on 28 July 2026, stateless by design.
- **Claude Code:** starts in auto mode; defers MCP tools until needed.
- **Government:** Claude for Government generally available, FedRAMP High, 30 Sep 2026.

> CURRENCY CHECK
>
> Answer with the architectural principle. Treat version details as a currency check.

How the questions are shaped

- **One best answer from four:** just over half the bank.
- **Choose two from five:** about two items in five.
- **"Part of the solution":** the two picks together make one answer.
- **"A complete solution":** each pick works on its own.
- **BEFORE items:** which two steps must come first. About one in ten.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Shares come from this course's analysis of a 125-item practice bank, not from Anthropic.

Meet Corvane Partners

- **A Claude partner consultancy** in Manchester and Boston, 140 staff.
- **You are one of its architects:** discovery, design, build, handoff.
- **Every engagement ends** with ADRs, runbooks and an evaluation framework.
- **Three clients** carry the examples. Fresh companies test transfer.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Fictional, like every organisation in this course.

Three clients, three kinds of constraint

A building society, a health network and a software company.

CLIENT	WANTS	HARD CONSTRAINT
Mereside Mutual	Agent assist, extraction	UK GDPR; credit is high-risk
Quillon Health	Summaries, patient portal	HIPAA and its BAA
Tallyhawk	Support agent, Claude Code	Customer audit trails

ON THE EXAM

Each client brings a different constraint. Watch how it reshapes the design.

How to use this course

- **Pause at every scenario** and commit before the walkthrough.
- **Study the wrong answers.** Why they fail is what transfers.
- **Watch in order.** Later modules use earlier vocabulary.
- **Sit the three papers last:** 63 questions, one full exam, timed.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Watching a walkthrough you never answered feels like learning. Mostly, it is not.

> Quillon Health wants an agent that drafts discharge summaries from the inpatient record. Each run takes several minutes and calls several tools. A developer proposes Claude Managed Agents, so Quillon need not run the agent loop or its sandbox.
>
> Quillon's API organisation is HIPAA-ready under its BAA. Anthropic's documentation says Managed Agents is not currently eligible for BAA coverage.

What should Corvane recommend?

A Use Managed Agents, removing patient names from each record first

B Run the agent loop in Quillon's own service, calling the API in its HIPAA-ready organisation

C Use Managed Agents for the pilot, and move under the BAA once value is proven

D Use Managed Agents with a self-hosted sandbox, so files stay on Quillon's servers

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane recommend?

A Use Managed Agents, removing patient names from each record first

Removing names is not de-identification. The record is still health information.

B Run the agent loop in Quillon's own service, calling the API in its HIPAA-ready organisation

Keeps every step inside BAA coverage, using only eligible API features.

C Use Managed Agents for the pilot, and move under the BAA once value is proven

A pilot on real patient records is still processing them. The constraint applies now.

D Use Managed Agents with a self-hosted sandbox, so files stay on Quillon's servers

Where tools run does not change the service's eligibility. Sessions still pass through it.

THE SIGNAL

Patient data plus a service outside BAA coverage: eliminate it, then design within what is covered.

> Mereside Mutual's underwriters assess about 400 mortgage applications a day. Affordability is a fixed calculation: verified income, existing commitments and a stressed interest rate, applied exactly as the lending policy states.
>
> Underwriters spend most of their time typing figures from payslips and bank statements into the system.

Where should Claude sit in this design?

A Claude calculates affordability from the documents and recommends approve or decline

B Claude replaces the rules engine, with the lending policy held in its system prompt

C Nowhere, because lending decisions are regulated and high-risk

D Claude extracts the figures into a fixed schema, a rules engine calculates, and an underwriter decides

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Where should Claude sit in this design?

A. Claude calculates affordability from the documents and recommends approve or decline

Exact arithmetic belongs in code, and a lending decision needs a qualified human.

B. Claude replaces the rules engine, with the lending policy held in its system prompt

A prompt is less predictable and harder to audit than tested code for fixed rules.

C. Nowhere, because lending decisions are regulated and high-risk

Too absolute. High-risk use needs human review, not a ban on assistance.

D. Claude extracts the figures into a fixed schema, a rules engine calculates, and an underwriter decides

Claude does the messy reading; code does exact rules; a person decides.

THE SIGNAL

Messy documents to structured fields is Claude's job. Fixed rules belong in code.

> Quillon's brief for the patient-portal assistant reads: leadership hopes to cut call-centre volume by a quarter. Patient messages contain health information, so everything that touches them must be covered by the BAA.
>
> The CIO would prefer the newest model. The contract says replies must begin within two seconds at the 95th percentile. The team would like to reuse last year's chatbot vendor.

Which two are hard constraints, to apply before comparing anything else? Choose two.

A Cutting call-centre volume by a quarter

B BAA coverage for everything that touches patient messages

C The CIO's preference for the newest model

D Replies beginning within two seconds at the ninety-fifth percentile

E Reusing last year's chatbot vendor

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two are hard constraints, to apply before comparing anything else? Choose two.

A. Cutting call-centre volume by a quarter

A goal to optimise towards and measure, not a pass or fail gate.

B. BAA coverage for everything that touches patient messages

Legal and contractual. Any option outside coverage is out.

C. The CIO's preference for the newest model

A preference. Model choice follows the requirements and testing.

D. Replies beginning within two seconds at the ninety-fifth percentile

Written into the contract, measurable, and binding.

E. Reusing last year's chatbot vendor

A wish. It may influence cost, but it eliminates nothing.

THE SIGNAL

Hard constraints are binding and testable: law, contract, data boundary. Goals and preferences come later.

> Tallyhawk's support agent must tell customers when their next engineer visit is booked. The scheduling service already has a stable internal REST endpoint that answers in about 40 milliseconds.
>
> Only this agent needs the lookup, and every support reply waits on it.

Which integration should Corvane design?

A Wrap the scheduling service in an MCP server, so any future client can reuse it

B Add a scheduling agent and hand each lookup to it, agent to agent

C Define a tool that calls the existing endpoint directly, with a read-only scoped credential

D Load each customer's full schedule into the system prompt on every request

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which integration should Corvane design?

A Wrap the scheduling service in an MCP server, so any future client can reuse it

Portability is not asked for. It adds a server to build and run.

B Add a scheduling agent and hand each lookup to it, agent to agent

An extra model hop adds latency and cost to a stateless lookup.

C Define a tool that calls the existing endpoint directly, with a read-only scoped credential

Stateless, fast, stable, one consumer: the direct path, with least privilege.

D Load each customer's full schedule into the system prompt on every request

Wasted tokens, stale between requests, and more data than the question needs.

THE SIGNAL

Change one detail: if three products needed the same lookup, MCP would start to win.

In five lines

- The exam tests **judgement across a system's whole life**, not API recall.
- **63 items, 120 minutes, 720 to pass.** Read how many answers each item wants.
- **Design plus integration is 36%.** Claude Code setup is 7%.
- **Know the map:** models, API features, tools, Skills, runtimes, Claude Code, platforms.
- **Eliminate, then optimise.** One broken hard constraint ends an option.

> COMING UP
>
> Next: from business problem to Claude solution. Is Claude even the right component?